Philosophy · Epistemology · AQA A-level (7172)

Reliabilism

A workbook to use alongside the lesson slides: consolidate the theory, then practise the exam questions.

Name ..... Date .....

Reliabilism is a theory of what knowledge is. It asks where a belief came from: was it produced by a process we can rely on? Each part of this workbook matches a section of the slides, so you can pick it up even if you missed a lesson.

In this handout

1. What reliabilism claims
2. Reliable cognitive processes
3. An advantage: animals and babies
4. A problem: Henry in barn country
5. Exam questions (3, 5, 5 and 12 marks)

Part 01 What reliabilism claims

Use with slide 2.

> **Key Thesis**
> To have knowledge, your belief must have three ingredients. It must be (1) true, (2) believed, and (3) the result of a reliable cognitive process.

Exercise 1 Fill the gaps

Use each word from the word bank once.

Reliabilism says that I know P if P is ....., I ..... P, and my belief is the result of a ..... cognitive process. A reliable cognitive process is a mental or psychological process that delivers a high amount of ..... information. Three standard examples are sense-experience, ... and .....

Word bank accurate · believe · memory · reliable · testimony · true

Part 02 Reliable cognitive processes

Use with slides 3 and 4.

A reliable cognitive process is any mental or psychological process that delivers a high amount of accurate information. There are three standard processes: sense-experience, memory and testimony.

What reliabilism is, and is not, saying

It is not saying

If someone has told you something, or if you remember it, or think you see it, then it is knowledge.

It is saying

If something is true, and you see it because it is true, or remember it, or are given testimony about it because it is true, then you have knowledge.

Key idea The process has to connect your belief to the truth. Having seen, remembered or been told is not enough on its own.

Exercise 2 Is it knowledge for the reliabilist?

The first two rows are done for you. Complete the rest, then add one example of your own.

The belief, and how I got it	Which process?	Is the process reliable here? Why?	Knowledge?
I look out of the window and see that it is raining. It is raining.	*Sense-experience*	*Yes. I see rain because it is raining.*	*Yes*
A friend who is only guessing tells me the shop is open. It happens to be open.	*Testimony*	*No. A guess does not deliver accurate information.*	*No*
I remember leaving my keys on the kitchen table. They are there.			
My teacher has checked the timetable and tells me the exam is on Tuesday. It is.			
My horoscope says I will get good news today. I do get good news.			
I 'remember' locking the door, but I am thinking of yesterday. By chance, the door is locked.			
My own example:			

Part 03 An advantage: animals and babies

Use with slide 5.

More intellectualist theories of knowledge find it difficult to explain how an animal or a baby has knowledge. It is unlikely, for example, that animals form valid arguments in their minds, with premises and a conclusion.

Reliabilism allows animals and young children to gain knowledge. It does not need intellectual faculties to function. It only assumes that we need basic cognitive processes to gain knowledge.

Exercise 3 Explain the advantage

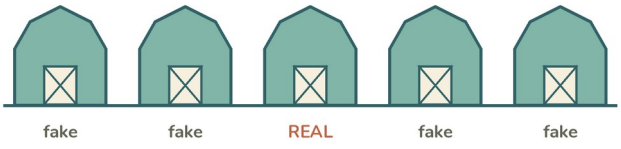
a) Give one thing an animal or a baby seems to know. Which reliable process produces the belief?

b) Why would a theory that requires arguments struggle to count this as knowledge, and why does reliabilism not?

Part 04 A problem: Henry in barn country

Use with slide 6.

Henry is driving through barn country, where almost all of the 'barns' are fakes that look real from the road. He stops in front of the one real barn and believes that he is seeing a barn.



Barn country: from the road, the fakes look exactly like the real barn.

1. Henry believes he is seeing a barn.
2. Henry is seeing a barn.
3. Henry has got his belief from a reliable cognitive process.

But he still cannot be said to know, because his belief is purely accidental. Had he stopped anywhere else, he would have believed and thought the same thing.

Exercise 4 Test Henry's belief

Answer Yes or No, with a short reason.

Question	Yes or No, because…
Is Henry's belief true?	
Does Henry believe it?	
Did the belief come from a reliable cognitive process?	
So, according to reliabilism, does Henry know?	
Do we think Henry really knows?	

a) Explain why Henry's true belief is 'purely accidental'.

b) What does this show about reliabilism's three ingredients? Are they enough for knowledge?

Check your understanding

Tick one box for each statement. Be honest: this tells you what to revisit on the slides.

I can…	Not yet	Nearly	Secure
define reliabilism precisely (slide 2)			
explain what a reliable cognitive process is, with examples (slides 3 and 4)			
explain one advantage of reliabilism (slide 5)			

I can...	Not yet	Nearly	Secure
explain how Henry in barn country is a problem for reliabilism (slide 6)			

Part 05 Exam questions

Use with slide 8. Plan first, then write. Aim for precise terms and clear steps.

Question 1 What is reliabilism? (3 marks)

Aim: a precise definition in two or three sentences. No examples needed.

Question 2 Explain the idea of a reliable cognitive process and how this fits into the definition. (5 marks)

Plan: say what a reliable cognitive process is, give an example, then show where it fits in the three ingredients.

Question 3 Explain one advantage of reliabilism. (5 marks)

Plan: state the advantage, explain the difficulty other theories face, then show how reliabilism avoids it.

Plan for Question 4

One line each: reliabilism's three ingredients, the barn country case, which ingredients Henry meets, why he still does not know, what this shows.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Question 4 **Outline and explain how the barn country thought experiment undermines reliabilism.** **(12 marks)**

No evaluation needed: marks come from precise terms and each step following from the last.